



Mastering Can and Could at Work

Practical English for Chilean
Professionals

A Common Office Scenario

Imagine you are in a meeting. Your boss asks for a report that was due yesterday.

Do you say:

- 'I **can't** do it'?
- 'I **couldn't** do it'?

Knowing the difference changes how professional you sound. Let's explore why.



Can vs. Can't: The Present



ABILITY & POSSIBILITY

Use **Can** for things you are able to do *right now* or generally in the present.

- 'I **can** speak English and Spanish.'
- 'I **can** join the Zoom call at 3 PM.'

Example

Negative: 'I **can't** open the PDF because I don't have the password.'

Comparing Present and Past

Present (Can)

Used for current skills or today's schedule.

- 'I **can** use Excel.'
- 'We **can** meet now.'

Past (Could)

Used for past skills or prior events.

- 'As a student, I **could** study all night.'
- 'I **couldn't** call you yesterday.'



Being Polite with 'Could'

PROFESSIONALISM

In a professional setting, we use **Could** to be more polite when asking for things.

Compare these:

- '**Can** you help me?' (Direct/Informal)
- '**Could** you help me?' (Polite/Professional)

Key point

Use 'Could you...' when speaking to clients or your supervisor to show respect.



Check Your Understanding

1.

Can

a) Past inability (e.g., yesterday).

2.

Couldn't

b) Present ability or possibility.

3.

Could

c) Polite request or past ability.

4.

Can't

d) Present inability or impossibility.

Check Your Understanding



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d) Present inability or impossibility.

The Project Deadline

Listen to the audio and answer the questions



A conversation about a missing report

▶ Play audio

- 1 Why didn't Elena finish the report yesterday?
- 2 What is Elena's deadline for the report today?
- 3 Why can't Elena attend the meeting at 4 PM?
- 4 What polite request did Mr. Silva make?

Answers on the next slide...

The Project Deadline



Check your answers below



A conversation about a missing report

▶ Play audio

- 1 Because the system was down.
- 2 Noon (12:00 PM).
- 3 She has an appointment.
- 4 He asked if she could help with a presentation or email the slides.

Grammar Summary



Ability

'I **can** code in Python.' vs
'I **could** code when I was
20.'



Permission

'**Can** I use this chair?'
(Casual) vs '**Could** I use
this chair?' (Polite)



Possibility

'We **can** win the contract.'
vs 'We **could** have won if
we tried harder.'

Professional Politeness Check

In a formal email to a new client, 'Can you send the contract?' is more appropriate than 'Could you send the contract?'



TRUE



FALSE

Now it's time to explain whv...

Professional Politeness Check

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Why is that?

- a) 'Could' is more tentative and polite, which is better for professional relationships with clients.
- b) 'Can' is always better because it is shorter and more direct in business.

Answers on the next slide...

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Speaking Practice



Think about your first week at your current job. What are 2 things you **CAN** do now that you **COULDN'T** do then?

Speaking Practice



You might have said...

I can lead meetings in English now.

I couldn't understand the technical software when I started.

I can manage the team budget effectively.

I couldn't speak to international clients comfortably back then.